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BANGLADESH IN 1972: NATION BUILDING IN A NEW STATE

/ Rounaq Jahan

One of the traumatic events of 1971 was the disintegration of Pakistan and the emergence of the new nation state, Bangladesh. The birth of Bangladesh was in many ways a unique phenomenon, for Bangladesh was the first country to emerge out of a successful national liberation movement waged against "internal colonialism" in the new states.[1] While the bloody birth of Bangladesh created widespread sympathies for the new nation, it also led to doubts about its viability and stability. A poor, over-crowded land, its economy ruined by a nine-month-long Pakistani military occupation and a national liberation war, Bangladesh was looked upon by many as an "international basket case."[2] Surrounded on three sides by India, which played a decisive role in its birth, Bangladesh appeared destined to be a client state of India. These fears about Bangladesh's economy and sovereign existence seemed justified given the absence of any well-organized administrative-political structure in the new state. With its charismatic leader Sheikh Mujibur Rahman in prison in Pakistan, the Awami League regime's ability to hold the new nation together and create a national political community out of various warring factions was doubted by many. It was widely believed that chaos and bloodbath would follow the liberation of Bangladesh.[3]

In the first year following liberation, many of these early predictions proved to be wrong. In 1972 the economy of Bangladesh slowly recovered from the previous year's disruption, and a famine, which was almost universally feared, was avoided. The anticipated bloodbath did not materialize in

[1]I have borrowed the term "internal colonialism" from the New Left writings. By internal colonialism I refer to the process of domination and exploitation of one ethnic group by another within a country. In most of the new states which have plural societies, early modernizing ethnic groups dominate the power elite. Once in power, these ethnic groups follow a public policy which perpetuates their unequal power relations with other groups.

[2]Ambassador U. Alexis Johnson reportedly made this remark in a meeting of the N.S.C.s Special Action Group on December 6, 1971, which was later published by columnist Jack Anderson; see *The New York Times*, January 6, 1972.

[3]See Kushwant Singh, "Homecoming in Bangladesh," *The New York Times Magazine*, January 30, 1972.

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Bangladesh, and the nation's claim as a sovereign entity was recognized by 97 countries. The Awami League regime slowly established its authority, started the difficult process of building a political structure, and in the first twelve months achieved a mixed degree of success.

Building a New Political Structure: Use of Charisma for Political Institution Building

Like many other new states, Bangladesh at its birth faced the formidable problem of simultaneously building an input and an output sector—both a state apparatus and a political community.[4] The two major instruments of a state apparatus, *i.e.*, the civil bureaucracy and the military, were in disarray at the time of the new state's birth. The senior and more experienced of the Bengali civil servants and military officers were working with the central government and were left in Pakistan. In the post-liberation period, not only did Bangladesh find itself deprived of the services of its experienced civil and military bureaucracy, but also schism and factionalism affected the morale and discipline of the civil service and the military left in Bangladesh. After liberation schism arose both in the civil service and in the military between the "collaborators" and the "patriots," and amongst the various organizational and factional groups.[5]

Not only was the output sector ill-organized and factionalized, but also the input sector, *i.e.*, political parties, was weak. The national liberation movement was carried out in the name of the Awami League which had swept the polls in Bangladesh in 1970.[6] Though the Awami League's name was used to lend the leadership of the liberation movement legitimacy, the party mostly provided the movement with "front" leadership by establishing a government-in-exile and managing the external relations and publicity for the liberation movement. The leadership of the actual fighting was in the hands of the various factions of the *Mukti Bahini* (freedom fighters). There was little coordination between these two sets of leadership, and, at the later stage of the movement, conflict arose between the two. The Awami League leadership came under fire from the *Mukti Bahini* which claimed that the former was a do-nothing-group living in luxury in Calcutta.[7] In the post-liberation period there were doubts as to the capability of the Awami League government to exercise control and establish authority over the whole of Bangladesh. The various factions of the *Mukti Bahini*—numbering between 100,000 and 200,000 armed men—posed a threat to the fledgling Awami League regime. The law and order problem was compounded by the pres-

[4]For an elaboration of this problem, see Rounaq Jahan, *Pakistan Failure in National Integration* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1972).

[5]After liberation various cleavages developed in Bangladesh. Those who went in exile to India claimed to be the true patriots and those who stayed back were looked down upon as collaborators. Conflict also arose between the civil servants and technocrats of the planning commission, between the former central and provincial services.

[6]In the 1970 election, the Awami League won 167 out of 169 seats alloted to East Pakistan.

[7]Source: Personal interviews with former members of the *Mukti Bahini.*

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ence of nearly half a million non-Bengalis who were looked upon by the Bengalis as collaborators and traitors.[8]

The Awami League regime had a shaky start. After the liberation of Dacca on December 16, 1971, it took the Awami League government in exile five days to come to Dacca and establish a government. In the first two weeks it did little except to pray for the release of its leader Sheikh Mujibur Rahman from prison in Pakistan. Its call for the surrender of arms went largely unheeded and the task of providing protection to the non-Bengalis was entrusted to the Indian army. The year 1972 started with the good news of Sheikh Mujibur Rahman's imminent release. On January 8, Mujib was released and flown to London where in a press conference he showed an immediate grasp of the political realities in Bangladesh in spite of a nine-month-long solitary confinement in Pakistani prison.[9] Before his release it was feared that even Mujib would not be able to establish his authority in Bangladesh, since he was absent during the whole period of the liberation movement. But he proved these predictions to be wrong by immediately and firmly grasping the reins of power in Bangladesh. He returned to Bangladesh on January 10, with a short stop over in Delhi, which, according to some observers, was an indication of Sheikh Mujib's charting a course independent of India. Upon arrival in Dacca, Mujib was given a hero's welcome, and in the same day in a public speech he laid down the major principles of his regime.[10] He rejected the possibilities of any ties with Pakistan except on the basis of mutual respect as separate sovereign entities. He reiterated the Awami League regime's stand that collaborators and prisoners of war guilty of crimes would be tried, and he proclaimed that the policies of his regime would be based on the principles of secularism, democracy, and socialism.

The day after his arrival in Dacca Mujib, as the president of the republic, issued a provisional constitutional order which stipulated a unitary, parliamentary government for Bangladesh. The provincial and national assemblies were amalgamated into one body called the Constituent Assembly. Freedom of press and speech and other fundamental rights were allowed subject to certain qualifications, *i.e.*, a ban on right-wing parties which had collaborated with the Pakistan army during the liberation war and other restrictions on the collaborators.[11] The day after the announcement of the constitution order, Sheikh Mujib stepped down as president, became the prime minister, swore in an extended cabinet, and thus, within forty-eight hours of his re-

[8]Some non-Bengalis collaborated with the Pakistan military during the liberation movement, and after liberation many observers anticipated mass killings of non-Bengalis by the Bengalis. Even though emotions were high such a mass killing was avoided.

[9]See *The Observer* (London), January 9, 1972.

[10]*The Bangladesh Observer*, January 11, 1972. It is interesting to note that in his first public speech Mujib mentioned only three of his now famous four principles. Nationalism was missing from the list then and was only later added.

[11]The right wing parties were banned by the Awami League even before Mujib's release.

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turn, became the effective head of government ruling out all possibilities of playing a Gandhi-type role. At a press conference on January 14, Mujib promised early drafting of a constitution and a socialist economy for Bangladesh.

On January 17, Mujib called for the surrender of arms by the *Mukti Bahini* within a ten-day time limit, and he reiterated his earlier belief that power does not come from the barrel of the gun but rather stems from the people.[12] Mujib put all his charisma behind this call for surrender of arms. On January 24, he went to Tangail to preside over the ceremony of surrender of arms by Kader Siddiqui (nicknamed Tiger) and his troops—the largest and most powerful single faction of the *Mukti Bahini.* In the next few days other groups of the *Mukti Bahini* surrendered their arms. And on January 30, as a show of Mujib's own strength *vis-a-vis* the different factions of the *Mukti Bahini,* some 50,000 arms were surrendered by the *Mujib Bahini* who came to Dacca from all the districts.[13] Mujib also appealed to the non-Bengalis to integrate with the Bengalis;[14] and the Bengali soldiers replaced the Indian soldiers in providing protection to the non-Bengali localities. Finally, on March 12, all Indian troops were withdrawn from Bangladesh.[15] Civil administration also slowly recovered from the disruption of 1971. Within two months district officers were appointed in all the districts and a decision was taken to upgrade the subdivisions into districts.

In the first few months Mujib ruled by means of his charisma, but he also began a deliberate process of building a political structure, and he put all his charisma behind this effort. From the beginning the Awami League regime put priority on the political process. The Indian model of political development appears to be its model. This means that it wants to have a parliamentary democracy with a single dominant party and a relatively free political process with restrictions on the extreme left and the extreme right. To provide a basic political framework for the country, the regime concentrated on drafting a constitution.

Constitution

One of the great achievements of the Awami League regime in its first twelve months in power was the successful completion of the task of constitution-making. In his first press conference in Dacca, Mujib promised the people an early constitution.[16] On March 23, the Constitution Assembly Order was promulgated. On April 10, the Constituent Assembly met for two days and created a thirty-four member special committee headed by Law

[12] *The Bangladesh Observer,* January 19, 1972.

[13] *Ibid,* January 31, 1972. *Mujib Bahini* was created as the Awami League's armed support group, and after liberation *Mujib Bahini* refused to surrender arms until Sheikh Mujib was released.

[14] *The Bangladesh Observer,* January 11, 15, 1972.

[15] *Ibid.* March 13, 1972. However the Indian army was called back for a short time to help the Bangladesh army in military operations in the Chittagong Hill Tracts. See *The Bangladesh Observer,* March 24, 1972.

[16] *The Bangladesh Observer,* January 15, 1972.

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Minister Dr. Kamal Hossain and entrusted with the task of drafting a constitution. The committee made it obvious that it would draft the constitution quickly. One of the reasons for this urgency was that the regime wanted to avoid the tragic experiences of the Pakistan period when a delay in constitution-making led to the loss of legitimacy of the Muslim League regime. The other reason behind this urgency was that the Awami League regime wanted to provide a basic political framework according to its own preferences before serious controversies could arise over the fundamentals of the constitution. The constitution was drafted within six months, and it was passed by the Constituent Assembly—where the Awami League had an overwhelming majority—in record time. The Constituent Assembly met on October 12, and it passed the constitution bill on November 4. The constitution became effective on December 15—exactly a year after the liberation of Bangladesh.

The constitution of Bangladesh is an interesting document since it is an attempt to facilitate political development in Bangladesh according to the Indian model. The constitution incorporates a number of provisions with an eye to ensure the stability of the system. Thus it stipulates that a member of parliament will lose his parliamentary seat when he loses his party membership either because of resignation or expulsion from the party. It also provides that the prime minister can ask the president to dissolve the parliament and seek fresh elections when a vote of no confidence is passed against him, but it does make the parliament, rather than the court, the supreme authority in the state.

The constitution faced little criticism in the Constituent Assembly since there were only one opposition and two independent members.[17] The opposition outside the Assembly was also mild as compared to the experiences of the Pakistani period. The major criticisms center around four points: first, the constitutional provisions regarding parliamentary supremacy and party discipline were criticized for aiming to create a unique system of dictatorship by the prime minister;[18] second, the extensive emergency powers permitted in the Constitution and the limitations put on the fundamental rights by the emergency provisions led to the charge that the document was intended for a "perpetual" emergency;[19] third, the provision of indirect election for the ten women members of parliament was criticized by the women's lobby as a regressive step;[20] and finally, the "socialist" provisions of the Constitution failed to satisfy the socialists who thought that making socialism a part of the directive principles of state, without making that principle enforceable in a court of law, would not lead to the establishment of socialism in Bangladesh. One leading Bengali intellectual referred to the Constitution as a "fundamental measure against socialism, democracy, na-

[17]The opposition members did not sign the Constitution after it was passed.
[18]Badruddin Umar, "A Constitution For 'Perpetual' Emergency," *Holiday* (Dacca), October 29, 1972.
[19]*Ibid.*
[20]*Holiday* (Dacca), October 22, 1972.

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tionalism and secularism."[21] In general, however, it created little passionate public controversy. The National Awami Party (Muzaffar faction) and the Communist Party (Moni Singh faction) welcomed the Constitution while suggesting some modifications and amendments. The National Awami Party (Bhashani faction) and the *Jatiyo Samajtantrik Dal* (JSD) came out with more vigorous opposition and demanded a referendum, though they did agree that a bad Constitution was better than none at all.[22] While the Constitution evoked little heated opposition, it also failed to inspire the vast majority of the youth who would have liked to see some more radical provisions included. Still, it did provide the country with a basic political framework. Early drafting of the Constitution and the announcement of the parliamentary election date in March 1973 helped to stabilize the emerging political structure in Bangladesh. The Awami League regime's emphasis on building the party further strengthened the political structure.

Party Building

Sheikh Mujibur Rahman and the Awami League had long been sensitive to the need of strengthening the party organization. Even during the liberation war, the Awami League government-in-exile was attentive to the party's interests. The Awami League tried to have total control over the liberation movement. It formed a government-in-exile composed only of Awami Leaguers and rejected the pleas of other parties—especially of the Muzaffar and Bhashani factions of the National Awami Party—to form a national coalition. At the later stage of the liberation movement, when factional opposition to the Awami League became evident, the Awami League created a special force—the *Mujib Bahini*—composed of youthful supporters of the party. This group, which was reportedly 60,000 to 70,000 strong, was expected to lend support to the Awami League regime in the post-liberation period.[23]

Following liberation, the Awami League again formed a party government and from the beginning put priority on party-building tasks. Within a month after Mujib's release in mid-February, the Awami League Working Committee met in Dacca and decided to separate the party organization from the parliamentary party. This meant that ministers were barred from holding any Party office,[24] but the factional fights within the Awami League compelled Mujib to continue as Party President. Consequently, in early April, the Awami League Council reversed its earlier decision and officially requested Sheikh Mujib to continue in his office as well as to nominate the other office bearers of the party.[25] Mujib chose a compromise candidate—Zillur Rahman—as the new General Secretary of the Party. The organiza-

[21]Badruddin Umar, "The Proposed Constitution: A Fundamental Measure Against Socialism, Democracy, Nationalism, and Secularism," *Holiday*, October 22, 1972.
[22]*The Bangladesh Observer*, October 21, 1972.
[23]Source: personal interviews with former members of the *Mukti Bahini*.
[24]*The Bangladesh Observer*, February 18, 1972.
[25]*Ibid*, April 7, 1972.

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tional side of the Party was left to the young members, especially to the two former student leaders—Tofail Ahmad and Abdur Razzaq.[26]

In reorganizing and revitalizing the Party, the Awami League is emphasizing two factors, *i.e.*, the strengthening of the youth fronts and the use of patronage. The Awami League used in the past and is still using its student and labor fronts—Student League and *Jatiyo Sramik League*—for recruiting support for the Party. To coopt the members of the former *Mujib Bahini* and to act as a counter to the JSD (which was becoming increasingly popular with the youth), the Awami League, in November, started a new youth front called *The Awami Jubo League* and headed by Sheikh Mujib's nephew, Sheikh Moni.[27] In addition to this emphasis on the youth fronts, the old-style method of party-building through patronage is also being followed. The Awami League, as the Party in power, has access to a vast amount of patronage. Through liberal distribution of permits and licenses, the Awami League can be expected not only to hold on to its original bourgeoisie support base but also to expand it further.[28]

Finally, the Awami League is using its greatest asset—its leader, Sheikh Mujibur Rahman. As well as being the father of the nation and the Prime Minister, Sheikh Mujib occasionally and judiciously projects his image as the Party leader. Thus, in his two mammoth and important public speeches in Dacca on June 7 and December 16, Mujib strongly defended his Party against the criticisms of his opponents and appealed for mass support of it.[29] In fact, for the purpose of party-building, a new ideology is being popularized—an ideology that again claims legitimacy from the charisma of the leader.

Mujibbad

Simply stated, Mujibbad stands for the four principles of nationalism, democracy, socialism and secularism which Mujib claims to be his ideals. The term Mujibbad was first coined by the Awami League's Students League, and it came to prominence in May when the Students League was split into two factions—one (Siddiqui-Makhan faction) supporting Mujibbad and the other (Rab-Siraj faction) supporting scientific socialism. From the Students League the slogan of Mujibbad was picked up by the young leaders of the Awami League and later by the Party hierarchy. Mujibbad is proclaimed as the new "ism" which seeks to correct the deficiencies of capitalism and communism. The Bangladesh Constitution incorporates the term to symbolize the guiding principles of the state, and it is likely that the establishment of Mujibbad will be one of the key election themes of the Awami

[26]Tofail Ahmad rose to fame during the 1968-69 movement against Ayub when he was the vice-president of Dacca University Central Students Union. Razzaq was the chief of the volunteer corps.

[27]*The Bangladesh Observer*, November 11, 1972.

[28]The opposition political forces claim that the Awami League is distributing licenses and permits for business among Party supporters and sympathizers.

[29]*The Bangladesh Observer*, June 8, December 17, 1972.

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League in 1973.[30] Already voluminous publications are coming out to explain Mujibbad.

This attempt to develop an ideology based on a personality cult, however, has hurt Mujib's image. By identifying the new political structure too closely with his personality, Mujib is held responsible for *all* the deficiencies of the new system. Even the personal failings of the Awami Leaguers are blamed on Mujib and Mujibbad.[31] Additionally, this attempt to build a personality cult is reminiscent of the Ayub era and hence is looked upon by many as a fascist trend.

Growth of an Opposition to the Awami League Regime

After liberation, when the Awami League formed the government in Bangladesh, it faced virtually no political opposition. The right wing parties, which had collaborated with the Pakistan army during the liberation war, were banned. The left wing parties, which had supported the liberation movement, were allowed to function, and, indeed, the Communist party opened its office in Dacca with much publicity. But these leftist parties were factionalized and weak. Sheikh Mujib's leadership was unquestioned; he was the *Bangabandhu* (friend of Bengal), the *Bangapita* (Father of the Bengali nation), and his arrival in Dacca was greeted by all parties, factions and leaders. In fact, the leaders of all leftist parties—Moni Singh, Muzaffar, Bhashani—urged the people to rally behind Mujib and work for national reconstruction.

Opposition to the Awami League, however, developed quickly. To start with there was the opposition from the "far left" and the "far right" which the regime branded as "Naxalites" and "Razakars."[32] It was decided to root out both these categories of opposition by force. A *Rakkhi Bahini* was formed in March by the regime for the purpose of internal security. In April-May, military operations were conducted in a number of districts to crush the Naxalites. Apart from the far left, opposition from the other parties and factions also became evident quite early. In March, Major Jalil, one of the leaders of the *Mukti Bahini,* was arrested for criticizing the role of the Indian army in Bangladesh. From May on the popular discontent against the Awami League became more voluble and visible. The non-availability of essential goods, the ever-rising price index, the unequal sharing of austerity, the corruption and nepotism of the Awami League leaders, charges of Indian influence in Bangladesh—all these factors led to a growing unpopularity of the Awami League. In early 1972 it appeared that the National Awami

[30]Most of the electioneering speeches given by the Awami League Leaders emphasize the establishment of Mujibbad; the party posters and pamphlets do the same.

[31]Thus the regime's failure to check the corruption of individual Awami Leaguers or Awami League supporters is blamed on Mujib—it is claimed that he is protecting these corrupt members.

[32]After liberation, in order to eliminate armed opposition, Mujib delivered a number of tough public speeches, in which he termed both the left and right factions of armed groups as enemies of the people.

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Party (Muzaffar faction)—which was pursuing a policy of being a responsible and respectable opposition—would inherit the "gaddi"[33] should the Awami League lose in popularity. The victory of its Student Union in the university elections in May tended to confirm this belief. But as discontent against the Awami League mounted, the National Awami Party failed to exploit popular feelings. By the end of the year its policy of cautious "me-tooism" had earned it the nickname of being the "B" team of the Awami League.

The initiative lost by the NAP (M) was taken up by the National Awami Party (Bhashani), a faction of the Awami League's own Students League, and the *Sramik League*, which later formed a new party in October called the *Jatiyo Samajtantrik Dal* (JSD). Bhashani at the beginning supported Mujib and his government. But when popular discontent against the Awami League rose, Bhashani, who had always been sensitive to popular moods, exploited the sentiments of mass frustrations. He called for a reduction of prices and led a hunger march in Dacca in early September. He took advantage of the fast-rising anti-India feeling by calling for resistance to Indian imperialism and for establishment of greater Bengal and Islamic socialism.[34] In November, Bhashani forged an electoral alliance with a number of other small parties and factions, including Ataur Rahman's National League. Bhashani has announced his decision to contest the next election, and his alliance can be expected to draw some right-wing support.[35]

As the year ended, the JSD was emerging as the strongest challenge to the Awami League regime.[36] The Party is composed of the dissident and radical factions of the Awami League's own student and labor fronts, *i.e.*, the Rab-Siraj faction of the Students League and the Sirajul Alam Khan faction of the *Sramik League*. The JSD also attracted Major Jalil to its fold. It has not yet formed a party platform and still has to make up its mind over whether or not to contest the next election. Both the program and the organizational setup of the Party and a decision on the election are expected to be announced after the Party's convention in late December. Thus far, the JSD has come forward with less systemic criticism of the regime; its major attack has been focused on corruption. But the Party has managed to recruit the support of a vast number of youth, as is evidenced by their victory in different college elections. This emphasis on youth and nationalism no doubt indicates certain authoritarian tendencies (indeed the party is, ironically, named National Socialist Party), and the JSD makes it clear that democracy is not on its priority list.

Most observers agree that the Awami League will win the coming election easily, though with a smaller popular vote than it received in 1970,

[33]Literally means the throne. It is generally used to refer to power.

[34]*The Bangladesh Observer*, October 31, 1972.

[35]Because of his anti-India stand and his criticism of the regime's policies towards the collaborators, Bhashani is believed to have picked up the support of the right.

[36]Sheikh Mujib's December 16 speech indicates that the regime is looking upon the JSD as a serious challenge.

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since there is still no viable alternative to it. The National Awami Party (M) and the Communist Party are discredited for too enthusiastically supporting the Awami League, the National Awami Party (B) is too factionalized, and the JSD has yet to form a country-wide organization.

The Economy

Even without the massive destruction of 1971, Bangladesh would have been an intolerably poor land. In 1969-70, the most recent normal year for Bangladesh, *per capita* annual income was taka 450.[37] The structure of the economy was primitive, with large-scale economy contributing a mere 6% of the GDP. Nearly half the population had a deficiency in calorie intake, and the literacy rate was as low as 17%. While the economy was underdeveloped to begin with, the destruction incurred in 1971 was extensive. A U.N. report estimated the cost of reconstruction in Bangladesh at $938 million.[38] Since liberation the Awami League regime has been faced with the three-fold problem of providing immediate relief to the returning refugees, reconstructing the economic infrastructure back to the 1969-70 level, and planning for a socialist economy in Bangladesh.

In order to provide relief and rehabilitation and to avert famine and starvation Bangladesh received large amounts of international aid through the U.N. and its affiliated agencies. In its task of reconstructing the economy, the regime claims commendable success. Within twelve months the various sectors of the economy recovered significantly from the losses of 1971. In 1972 there is some shortfall in agricultural production, due primarily to drought. Industrial production made a fast recovery. By August, most of the sectors of industrial production regained over 90% of their 1969-70 output.[39] Recovery in overhead has also been satisfactory. Chittagong port was cleared and all damaged big bridges, with the exception of one, were repaired. Foreign exports were pushed up, and by August, the balance of foreign trade stood at 175 million taka.[40] The regime also emphasized long and short range economic planning for a socialist economy. On March 26, the regime announced its decision to nationalize basic industries, banking and insurance.[41] In the agricultural sector the two major decisions of 1972 were to fix a ceiling of 100 bighas on landholdings and to exempt landholding of less than twenty-five bighas from taxation. The planning machinery was also strengthened. A planning commission was set up and the first five-year-plan of the country is expected to be published in early 1973.

In the economic sector, side-by-side with some impressive performances, there are also some glaring failures. First, there is the phenomenal rise in

[37]Source: Planning Commission, Government of the People's Republic of Bangladesh, *The Annual Plan*, 1972-73, p. 1.

[38]Source: *Ambassador Erna Sailer's Report on the Mission of High Level United Nations Consultants to Bangladesh*, vol. 1 (April 1972), mimeo, pp. 11-14.

[39]Source: Bangladesh Planning Commission.

[40]*Ibid.*

[41]*The Bangladesh Observer*, March 27, 1972.

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the cost of living index. The cost of living jumped from taka 208 in January to taka 297 in October—nearly 50%.[42] Second, the regime's economic policies created multiple middlemen in the system. As permits were sold and resold, prices skyrocketed. The border trade pact with India was yet another failure. Before liberation it was expected that there would be close, mutually beneficial economic cooperation between Bangladesh and India. But after liberation the trade agreement and the border trade pact failed to come up to earlier expectations. The high rate of smuggling embittered the economic relations between the two countries.[43] Finally, the Bangladesh army was sent to the border to tackle the smuggling problem, and the border trade pact was cancelled. As 1972 drew to a close, the major problems in the economic front remained rising prices—especially food prices—labor unrest, [44] multiplication of middlemen and heavy dependence on foreign aid.

Bangladesh and the World

Within a year of its independence, Bangladesh had been recognized by 97 countries, and had become a member of several international bodies —WHO, UNESCO, World Bank, IMF, etc. Its bid to be a member of the United Nations, however, was prevented by a Chinese veto in the Security Council. Since liberation Bangladesh has been pursuing an independent non-aligned foreign policy, and Mujib repeatedly proclaims his desire to make Bangladesh "The Switzerland of Asia."[45] Bangladesh is putting priority on amicable relationships with its neighbors. Friendship with India, its giant neighbor, is a cardinal principle of Bangladesh's foreign policy. In March, Bangladesh signed a treaty of peace and friendship with India based on the model of the Indo-Soviet treaty of 1971. Bangladesh is also keen to establish close relations with its other South and Southeast Asian neighbors. With the Soviet Union and the Soviet bloc countries Bangladesh has visibly warm relations. These countries supported the liberation movement in Bangladesh and after liberation granted quick recognition. With the United States the relationship is formal and low-profiled. The U.S. did not support the liberation movement and waited four months before granting Bangladesh recognition. Of the major powers only China still refuses to recognize Bangladesh, but, in spite of Chinese opposition, Bangladesh has expressed an interest in establishing friendly relations with Peking.[46]

The outstanding issues with Pakistan, however, remain to be solved. Pakistan refuses to recognize Bangladesh and is holding nearly a half million Bengalis in Pakistan as political hostages against its POWs. Bangla-

[42]Source: Bangladesh Planning Commission.

[43]Because of the high rate of smuggling, trade through the regular channels was minimal. Additionally, the high prices in Bangladesh were blamed on the smuggling.

[44]In spite of a governmental ban on strikes, labor unrest is chronic. The Awami League's labor front, the *Sramik League,* is factionalized and it often comes into conflict with the government.

[45]*The Bangladesh Observer,* January 15, 1972.

[46]In spite of the Chinese veto the Awami League regime refrained from criticizing Peking too vehemently.

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desh refuses to talk without prior recognition by Pakistan, and it insists on holding war crime trials of the POWs. So far mediation offers by third parties, *i.e.*, the United Kingdom and Indonesia, have failed to break the deadlock between the two countries, and the Indo-Pakistan summit in June also failed to normalize relations amongst the three subcontinental states.

To summarize, Bangladesh in 1972 slowly began its process of nation-building. The Awami League regime achieved a significant degree of success in restoring a war torn economy and building a new political structure. And though it was denied membership in the U.N., the country's existence as a sovereign entity is recognized as an unchallengeable reality. In the first year after liberation the new political structure showed remarkable stability. The system's real challenge however comes from the vast number of youth who were radicalized by the liberation movement without any precise ideological commitment. The alienation of the youth may yet spell disaster for the Awami League's system.

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